reconstruction in the second century BCE, following the end of the Maurya dynasty. Not only did it expand visibly in size, its enlarged brick dome now came to be encased in stone and surrounded by a stone balustrade. The epigraphs on the balustrade reveal a staggering extravagance of donations by sundry people who supported the building programme here, including the pupils of particular teachers, lay worshippers, bankers, merchants, mothers, housewives, monks, and nuns. The donors came from near and far, from cities associated with the early life of Ashoka such as Vidisha and Ujjayini, and from more distant ones like Prathisthanapura and Pokhara.[12]

Around the same time there becomes visible the start of a tradition of sculptural art marked by strikingly carved Buddhist reliefs of events and individuals, real and legendary. Within this tradition we now see, for the first time, the imaging of elements of architecture and artefacts that Ashoka had set up at places of Buddhist worship. Among the earliest of these Ashoka-centred portrayals are features that Ashoka had added to the Mahabodhi sacred area—such as the throne that he had donated and the temple which he had had built. Less than a hundred years after his interventions, these additions were represented on a massive stone railing at Bharhut near Rewa in Central India. The railing surrounded a stupa and, like the Sanchi specimen, was built with donations by pilgrims from distant places like Vidisha, Kaushambi, and Pataliputra.[13] Unlike Sanchi's relatively plain railing, though, the one in Bharhut was luxuriantly carved with bas reliefs devoted to various subjects ranging from life scenes of the Buddha to Jataka stories about the Buddha's previous births.[14] Naturally, Mahabodhi, where the Buddha attained enlightenment, appears graphically represented. Ashoka's embellishments to the scene of supreme holiness thereby themselves gain concrete embellishment.

At this point in time the Great Sage was not represented in human form, his presence being indicated by a series of symbols. Several of these—a Bodhi tree, a wheel, and a stupa, for instance—were integrally associated